GRAMMAR 2: ARTICLES

Articles are always used with nouns. A common problem is deciding which article to use with which noun. To overcome this problem, it is necessary to remember some important ideas about nouns and articles and how they relate to each other.

Basic Ideas about Nouns

- **Proper or common**
  - man/Mr Arthur Tan; university/National University of Singapore

- **Countable, uncountable or double**
  - Countable (can be counted; have a singular and a plural form):
    One book, two books, three books

  - Uncountable (cannot be counted, with only one form, always singular or always plural):
    Always singular – information, equipment, knowledge, machinery
    Always plural – pants, spectacles, pajamas

  - Double (can be either countable or uncountable with both a singular and a plural form):
    1) **Iron** rusts when wet. (uncountable)
    2) An **iron** is used for pressing clothes. (countable)
    3) **Diamond** is a very hard substance. (uncountable)
    4) Her engagement ring has two very big **diamonds**. (countable)
    5) **Statistics** is an important field. (uncountable - field of study)
    6) **The statistics** show that an increase in prices is likely. (countable – pieces of data)

- **Singular or plural**
  - Book/books; man/men; idea/ideas

- **Generic vs. specific, indefinite vs. definite (in a sentence)**
  - Generic – when a noun is used in a generalisation (fact or statement considered true of the entire population); a noun is used as a symbol
    1) **A banana** is yellow.
    2) **Bananas** are yellow.
    3) **A computer engineer** must be good at problem-solving.
    4) **Computer engineers** must be good at problem-solving.
    5) **Love** is a special way of feeling.
    6) **A mother's love** is always unconditional.
       The is sometimes used with a singular generic count noun.
    7) **The banana** is a delicious tropical fruit.
    8) **The computer** will play an increasingly large role in our lives.
    9) I am learning to play **the piano**.

  - Indefinite – indefinite nouns are actual things (not symbols), but they are not specifically identified
    1) I ate **a banana** this morning.
    2) I ate **some bananas** this morning.
    3) **A student** fell sick after eating porridge from the canteen.
    4) **Some students** fell sick after eating porridge from the canteen.

- Definite – when the specific noun referred to is known to both writer and reader (speaker and listener)
  1) Thank you for **the banana** which you gave me this morning.
  2) **The bananas** in the fruit basket were delicious.
  3) Thank you for **the fruit**.

Basic Ideas about Nouns and Articles

- **Article types**
  - A/An – Indefinite article
  - The – Definite article
  - Zero – No article

- **General guidelines for article usage**
  - A/An – Indefinite article
    Only used with singular countable nouns; the first time a singular countable noun is mentioned (but not always)
    1) Yesterday I saw **a** dog chasing **a** cat. The cat was chasing **a** mouse. The mouse ran into **a** hole. The hole was really small.

    When it doesn't matter (or we don't know exactly) which person or thing is being talked about (hence, an "indefinite" noun)
    1) Give me a book (any book will do).
    2) There's a man on the phone who is looking for a Mr Tan.

  - The – Definite article
    When you know or assume that the reader is familiar with or thinking about the same specific noun you are referring to
    1) Thanks for **the** bananas (which you gave me this morning.)
    2) Give it to **the** manager (you know who he is).

    The second time an indefinite noun is mentioned
    1) Yesterday I saw some dogs. **The** dogs were chasing a cat. **The** cat was chasing a mouse. **The** mouse ran into a hole. **The** hole was really small.

    Used with superlatives or ordinals
    1) She presented a paper in **the** first conference on thinking.
    2) **The** most beautiful house in Singapore was sold to a billionaire.

    Used with specifiers
    1) **The** only room that is available is SR1.
    2) The doctor found out **the** main cause of his illness.

    With *of*-phrases
    1) **The** price of gold fluctuates.
    2) **The** results of the investigation were inconclusive.
    3) None of **the** projects was satisfactory.
    4) All of **the** questionnaires were returned.

- Zero – No article
  Usually, no article is needed for the first mention of a plural or an uncountable noun.
  1) **Apples** are harvested in the fall. The apples are then stored in the cellar.
  2) **Love** is a special way of feeling. The love a mother has for her child is very special indeed.

Summary Guidelines for Article Usage

a)	***The sun*** is bright today. Please hand this book to ***the teacher***. Please open ***the door***. Jack is in ***the kitchen***.	GUIDELINE: Use ***the*** when you know or assume that your listener is familiar with and thinking about the same specific thing or person you are talking about.
b)	Yesterday I saw *some dogs*. ***The dogs*** were chasing *a cat*. ***The cat*** was chasing *a mouse*. ***The mouse*** ran into *a hole*. ***The hole*** was very small.	GUIDELINE: Use ***the*** for the second mention of an indefinite noun*; in b): first mention = *some dogs, a cat, a mouse, a hole* second mention = *the dogs, the cat, the mouse, the hole*
c) d)	*INCORRECT: The apples are my favorite fruit*. CORRECT: ***Apples*** are my favorite fruit. *INCORRECT: The gold is a metal*. CORRECT: ***Gold*** is a metal.	GUIDELINE: Do not use ***the*** with a plural count noun (e.g., *apples)* or a noncount noun (e.g., *gold)* when you are making a generalization.
e)	*INCORRECT: I drove car*. CORRECT: I drove ***a car***. I drove ***the car***. I drove ***that car***. I drove ***his car***.	GUIDELINE: Do not use a singular count noun (e.g., *car)* without: 1) an article (*a*/*an* or *the*), 2) a demonstrative pronoun (*this*/*that*), or 3) a possessive pronoun.

***The** is not used for the second mention of a generic noun. Compare:

1) What color is ***a banana*** (generic noun)? ***A banana*** (generic noun) is yellow.
2) Tom offered me ***a banana*** (indefinite noun) or an apple. I chose ***the banana*** (definite noun).

Exercise 1

In the following dialogues, decide whether the speakers should use *a, an,* or *the.* The first two have been done for you.

1. A: I have __an__ idea. Let's go on __a__ picnic on Saturday.
   B: Okay.

2. A: Did you have fun at __the__ picnic yesterday?
   B: Sure, I did. And you?

3. A: You'd better have _____ good reason for being late!
   B: I do.

4. A: Did you think _____ reason that Jack gave for being late was believable?
   B: Not really.

5. A: Where's my blue shirt?
   B: It's in _____ washing machine. You'll have to wear _____ different shirt.

6. A: I wish we had _____ washing machine.
   B: So do I. It would make it a lot easier to do our laundry.

7. A: What happened to your bicycle? ____ front wheel is bent.
   B: I ran into ____ parked car when I swerved to avoid ____ big pothole in the street.
   A: Did you damage ____ car?
   B: A little.
   A: What did you do?
   B: I left _____ note for _____ owner of _____ car.
   A: What did you write on _____ note?
   B: My name and address. I also wrote _____ apology.

8. A: Can you repair my car for me?
   B: What's wrong with it?
   A: _____ radiator has _____ leak, and one of _____ windshield wipers doesn't work.
   B: Can you show me where _____ leak is?

9. A: Have you seen my boots?
   B: They're in _____ closet in _____ front hallway.

Exercise 2

Complete the sentences with *a, an, the,* or *no article.* The first three have been done for you.

1. __⃠__ Beef is a kind of __⃠__ meat.

2. The beef we had for dinner last night was excellent.

3. Jack is wearing a straw hat today.

4. Jack likes to wear _____ hats.

5. _____ hat is _____ article of clothing.

6. _____ hats are _____ articles of clothing.

7. _____ brown hat on that hook over there belongs to Mark.

8. Everyone has _____ problems in _____ life.

9. My grandfather had _____ long life.

10. That book is about _____ life of Helen Keller.

11. Tommy wants to be _____ engineer when he grows up.

12. The Brooklyn Bridge was designed by _____ engineer.

13. John Roebling is _____ engineer who designed the Brooklyn Bridge. He died in 1869 from _____ infection. He died before _____ bridge was completed.

14. _____ people wear _____ jewelry to make themselves more attractive.

15. _____ jewelry Diana is wearing today is beautiful.

16. Mary is wearing _____ beautiful ring today. It is made of _____ gold and _____ rubies. _____ gold in her ring was mined in Canada. _____ rubies came from Myanmar.

17. One of the first things you need to do when you move to _____ new city is to find _____ place to live. Most _____ newspapers carry _____ advertisements (called "want ads") for _____ apartments that are for rent. If you find _____ ad for _____ furnished apartment, _____ apartment will probably contain _____ stove and _____ refrigerator. It will also probably have _____ furniture, such as _____ beds, _____ tables, ____ chairs, and maybe _____ sofa.

18. My wife and I recently moved to this city. Since we're going to be here only for _____ short time, we're renting _____ furnished apartment. We decided that we didn't want to bring our own furniture with us. _____ apartment is in _____ good location, but that's about the only good thing I can say about it. Only one burner on _____ stove works. _____ refrigerator is noisy, and _____ refrigerator door won't stay closed unless we tape it shut. _____ furniture is old and decrepit, too. Nevertheless, we're still enjoying living in this city. We may have to look for _____ another apartment, however.

Exercise 3: Articles

There is an error with articles in each of the sentences below. Circle the error and correct it.

1. When a person buys a car, he or she usually has to make down payment.

2. My friend called the police because one of neighbors was having a loud party.

3. Students learn material more easily when they have a homework.

4. Many doctors in the United States no longer wear the uniform during office hours.

5. My cousin always makes sure she has the driver's license when she goes out.

Exercise 4: Articles in formal definitions

Make a list of five terms you use often in your field of study. Write a formal, one-sentence definition for each term. Then check to see if you have used articles correctly in your sentence.

1. Term: _____

   Definition: _____

2. Term: _____

   Definition: _____

3. Term: _____

   Definition: _____

4. Term: _____

   Definition: _____

5. Term: _____

   Definition: _____

References:

Azar, B. S. (1989). *Understanding and using English grammar (2nd ed.)*. Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice Hall Regents.